

When to Stay versus When to Leave

Depending on the disaster, you may need to **Shelter-in-Place** or **Evacuate**. That is why it is important to be informed of emergencies in your area by subscribing to your county's emergency alert and warning system. The alert and warning system(s) can aid you in your decision to **Shelter-In-Place** or **Evacuate**.

Shelter-in-Place occurs when conditions require you to seek protection in your home, place of work/business, or other locations. Reasons to seek shelter include chemical/pollutants in the air, during an earthquake, tornado or hurricane, and active shooter threats.

To effectively **Shelter-in-Place**, you must first consider the hazard and then choose a place in your residence or building that is safe for that hazard.

If instructed by emergency officials to **Shelter-in-Place** you should:

- Bring your family and pets inside immediately.
- Tune in to emergency broadcast stations to stay informed.
- If necessary, lock doors and windows.
- If sealing is required, use duct tape and plastic to seal off doorways, air vents, outlets, windows, and fireplace dampers. Turn off air conditioning, forced-air heating systems, exhaust fans, ceilings fans, and clothes dryers. Cover the space under the door with a wet towel.
- If your children are at school, do not pick them up unless requested to do so, as they may be **Sheltering-in-Place** until emergency officials release them.

Evacuations occur when the current environment becomes so dangerous that Sheltering-in-Place is not safe. Disasters such as wildfire, floods, earthquakes, tsunamis, and volcanic eruptions may require escape from an area deemed unsafe.

Evacuations can generally occur one of two ways, first via an **Evacuation Warning** (voluntary/advisory) or second, via an **Evacuation Order** (mandatory). Local law enforcement agencies will issue the warning or order if the situation requires it. If you believe your safety may be compromised, evacuate early. There is no need to wait for an evacuation warning or order to leave. Evacuation Warnings or Evacuation Orders may vary in your jurisdiction so check with your local law enforcement office for more information.

- **Evacuation Warning:** This is time to prepare you, your family, and your pets to leave. It is generally a voluntary order given when emergency officials believe the disaster or its effects may expand into your area. They should be taken seriously as many factors can affect the spread of an incident. If you have any access and functional needs, such as medical or mobility issues, you should prepare to leave once an Evacuation Warning is issued.

- **Evacuation Order:** This is the official order to leave because the disaster is spreading to your area. These orders should be taken seriously as failure to follow an evacuation order unnecessarily endangers the lives of you, your family and emergency responders. Only when the evacuation order has been lifted can you return to your residence.

Evacuation warnings and orders can happen at any time. Pay attention to evacuation signs and emergency personnel such as law enforcement or fire officials as they may direct traffic out of an evacuation area.

Some jurisdictions will establish assembly points where people can gather and utilize public transportation to evacuate. Check with your local emergency management office or first responders for more information.

Lastly, if you have school-age children, be aware of the schools' emergency policies or plans, and determine who will pick up your children if you cannot during an incident.

What to do Before an Evacuation:

- Sign up for emergency alerts from local officials or your local news/radio stations. Download the [MyShake](#) Earthquake Early Warning app on the [CalAlerts](#) web page.
- Determine where you will go if you must leave and plan your routes and destinations.
 - How will you get there? Do you have sufficient transportation available or do you need evacuation assistance?
 - Will those places accommodate you and your pets too?
- Create a family/household communication and reunification plan in case of separation.
- Check with your neighbors and loved ones that may need assistance evacuating.
- Ensure your children's school(s) has your updated contact information and designate others who may pick up your children in your absence.
- Put together your "go-kit" and gather necessary supplies like food, water, medications/medical equipment if necessary, batteries, and clothes.
- Keep mobile phones and other electric equipment charged and gas tanks full.
- Tune your radios, televisions, or other devices to news sources for updates and stay informed.
- Take pictures/videos of your home and property before you leave if time permits.



During an Evacuation:

- Listen to emergency broadcast stations via radio or internet for updates. Check on-line or dial **2-1-1** if it is available in your area.
- If you go to a shelter, connect with your local first responders or emergency managers to locate available shelters.
- Check social media pages of your local emergency management office as they will post alerts and information.
- Take your emergency supplies or “go-kit.”
- Take your pets and pet supplies with you.
- If time allows, contact out of area/state relatives about your plan, where you are going, and when you plan to arrive.
- Consider leaving a note telling others when you left and where you are going.
- Wear durable shoes and clothing that will help protect you from the weather or hazards.
- Check with your neighbors in case they need help.
- Follow recommended routes out of the area.

After an Evacuation:

- Send messages to those on your contact list, friends, and family to let them know you have arrived at your destination safely.
- If you go to a shelter, check in with the shelter managers. They will provide a list of amenities or services provided at that location.
- Listen to authorities to find out when it is safe to return.



Going Home:

- Connect with your local law enforcement office to find out when it is safe to return home.
- If your home is damaged or destroyed, be aware of structural or non-structural hazards and use extreme caution around trees, power poles and lines, and other tall objects or structures that may have lost stability.

- Wear recommended personal protective equipment (PPE) when searching through debris for personal items to minimize exposure to harmful particles.
- Utility providers may put out boil water notices instructing residences that the tap water is not safe for consumption and will need to be boiled before use.
- Document and take photographs of any property damage, inventory your home/property for lost and damaged items, and contact your insurance provider for assistance.
- In case of power outages, food may have spoiled. **When in doubt, throw it out!** Throw away any frozen food that has been exposed to temperatures 40 degrees or higher for two hours or more, or that has an unusual odor, color, or texture. This includes discarding any medication that should be refrigerated unless the drug's label says otherwise. If a life depends on the refrigerated drugs, consult your doctor or pharmacist.
- If needed, contact your local emergency management office to find out about any housing or recovery assistance that may be available.

For those without a place to call home

- Connect with your local social services office to learn about programs available to help you recover.



Know Your Hazards

Earlier, we mentioned that there are a variety of hazards your family could face and should be prepared for. In this section we will cover the most common natural hazards that are likely to occur in California.

It is important to note that you should contact your local Office of Emergency Services and find out what hazards are most prevalent in your area.

Subscribing to emergency alerts and warnings will provide you the needed time to prepare your family in the event an emergency occurs.

The Cal OES [MyHazards](#) internet mapping tool is for the general public to discover hazards in your area. MyHazards allows you to type in your address, city, or zip code and find out what hazards (earthquake, flood, fire, and tsunami) are in your area. By identifying your local risk, you will increase your knowledge about natural disasters and then tailor your preparedness efforts to reduce your personal risk.

The screenshot shows the Cal OES MyHazards website. The header includes the Cal OES logo and the text "MyHazards" with the tagline "Helping reduce your risks from natural hazards". Navigation links for "Home", "Earthquake Risk", "Flood Risk", "Fire Risk", "Tsunami Risk", and "All Risks" are present. A search bar with the placeholder "California address" and buttons for "Search" and "Print" is visible. The main content area includes a section titled "How does MyHazards work?" with a description of the tool's purpose and a disclaimer. Below this is a section titled "What Natural Hazards Impact Your Neighborhood?" with instructions on how to use the website and a statement about the purpose of the site. The footer contains copyright information and links to "Conditions of Use", "Privacy Policy", "Contact Us", and "Website Accessibility Compliance".

Cal OES MyHazards

Helping reduce your risks from natural hazards

Home Earthquake Risk Flood Risk Fire Risk Tsunami Risk All Risks

How does MyHazards work?

MyHazards is a tool for the general public to discover hazards in their area (earthquake, flood, fire, and tsunami) and learn steps to reduce personal risk. Using the MyHazards tool, users may enter an address, city, zip code, or may select a location from a map. The map targets the location, and allows users to zoom and scroll to their desired view. The screen then presents information on the risks identified within the search radius, and recommended actions. MyHazards website performs best when using Internet Explorer. Hazard Data is approximate and data layer visibility are subject to the extent of the Map.

Type in your address below to learn how to address natural hazards in your area.

California address Search Print

What Natural Hazards Impact Your Neighborhood?

Use this website to discover the hazards that exist in your area and learn how to reduce YOUR risk! Remember, the best way to recover from disasters is by reducing the risks before a disaster strikes.

Please note: This web site is for general purpose use only. Real estate disclosure information can be obtained from your local city or county government. See our disclaimer below for more information regarding the limitations of this web service..

The Purpose of MyHazards web site

We all understand that disasters will continue to occur throughout California. Hazard mitigation saves lives, preserves property, and protects the environment during times of disaster. MyHazards facilitates the identification of hazards by individuals, businesses, and local government.

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Wildfires

A wildfire is an unplanned fire, which burns in a natural area such as a forest, grassland, or prairie, and has the potential to spread to residential or commercial areas. Wildfires can:

- Destroy homes and business and cause severe injury or even death.
- Happen anywhere, anytime. Risk increases with dry conditions and high winds.
- Disrupt transportation, gas, power, and communications lines.
- Can spread quickly in areas with high concentrations of fuels such as dried leaves, branches, and grass.
- Enable hot embers to travel great distances, starting smaller fires miles away from the original burn area.



Steps you can take to be prepared for wildfires:

- Remove/discard dried or dead leaves, brush, branches, and trees from around your home/property in order to create 100 feet of defensible space.
 - This includes removing leaves and debris from gutters, eaves, porches or decks to prevent embers from igniting your home.
- Remove flammable material like firewood or propane from within 30 feet of your home or outbuildings.
- Inspect and repair roof shingles or roof tiles to prevent embers from igniting a fire on the roof.
- Evacuate when ordered to evacuate, this allows firefighters unobstructed access to the area, clears the roads, and helps keep you safe.
- Connect garden hoses and fill any pools, hot tubs, garbage cans, tubs or other large containers with water, as firefighters have been known to use available water to put out fires.

Go to Cal Fire's [Ready for Wildfire](#) webpage for more information regarding wildfires, preparedness, and evacuations.

Supplies

Your list of emergency supplies can depend on the disaster. We have compiled a list of common things you should have whether you **Shelter-In-Place** or **Evacuate**.

Basic Supplies:

- Water – at least one gallon of water per person per day, for at least three days for drinking and sanitation
- Food – at least a 3-day supply of non-perishable food and a manual can opener
 - Infant formula, diapers, soothing supplies
 - Pet food and extra water for your pet(s)
- Prescription medication and glasses, copies of prescriptions
 - Immunization and allergy records
- Battery-powered or hand-crank radio and a National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) Weather Radio with Tone Alert
- Cell phone(s) with charger and a backup battery
- Flashlight(s)
- Extra Batteries
- First Aid Kits
- Personal hygiene products/Moist towelettes, garbage bags and plastic ties for personal sanitation
- Whistle to signal for help
- Wrench or pliers to turn off utilities
- Local Maps
- Important family documents such as recent photos of you and your family members in case of separation, copies of identification, financial and insurance information, copies of contact lists, and any other important records. These should be kept in a waterproof, portable container or saved on a thumb or external hard drive. You should also save these on your personal device or cellphone.
- Cash for emergency purposes as electronic payment systems may be out of service
- Sleeping bags and or blankets for each person



Useful Resources

State of California

CAL FIRE – <https://www.fire.ca.gov/>

CAL FIRE's Ready for Wildfire – <https://www.readyforwildfire.org/>

Cal OES

- MyHazards – <http://myhazards.caloes.ca.gov/>
- Preparedness Ambassadors – <http://www.caloes.ca.gov/preparednessambassadors>
- Wireless Emergency Alerts – <http://calalerts.org/signup.html>

California Department of Public Health (CDPH), Emergency Preparedness Office – <https://www.cdph.ca.gov/Programs/EPO/Pages/Program-Landing1.aspx>

California Department of Water Resources (DWR), Flood Preparedness – <https://water.ca.gov/What-We-Do/Flood-Preparedness>

California Geological Survey – <https://www.conservation.ca.gov/cgs>

California Governor's Office of Emergency Services (Cal OES) – www.caloes.ca.gov

California Health and Human Services Agency (CHHS) - Public Safety Power Shutoffs – Resource Guide – <https://www.chhs.ca.gov/blog/2019/10/25/public-safety-power-shutoffs-resource-guide/>

California Public Utilities Commission: Wildfire Safety – <https://www.cpuc.ca.gov/wildfiresinfo/>

CDPH Access and functional Needs – https://www.cdph.ca.gov/Programs/EPO/Pages/bp_access_functional_needs.aspx

MyShake™ Earthquake Early Warning App – <https://earthquake.ca.gov/mobile-application/>

Federal

California Volcano Observatory (CalVO) – <https://volcanoes.usgs.gov/observatories/calvo/>

Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA) Hazard Information Sheets – <https://www.fema.gov/media-library/resources-documents/collections/618>

National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) – <https://oceanservice.noaa.gov/facts/tsunami.html>

National Weather Service (NWS) – <https://www.weather.gov/>

Ready.gov: Plan Ahead for Disasters – <https://www.ready.gov>

- Emergency Financial First Aid Kit (EFFAK) – https://www.ready.gov/sites/default/files/2020-03/ready_emergency-financial-first-aid-toolkit.pdf

United States Geological Survey (USGS) Natural Hazard Programs – <https://www.usgs.gov/mission-areas/natural-hazards/programs>

Other

American Red Cross – <https://www.redcross.org>

California Fire Safe Council: Fire Safety Information for Residents – <https://cafiresafecouncil.org/resources/fire-safety-information-for-residents/>

Earthquake Country Alliance – <https://www.earthquakecountry.org/>

Great ShakeOut Earthquake Drills – <https://www.shakeout.org>

Listos California – <https://www.listoscalifornia.org/>

- COVID-19 Tips for people with Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities – http://www.listoscalifornia.org/wp-content/uploads/508_LIS_027_050520_IDD_tips_dAf.pdf
- COVID-19 Tips for Caregivers of people with Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities – http://www.listoscalifornia.org/wp-content/uploads/508_LIS_028_052020_IDD_tips_caregivers_dAf.pdf
- Health Profile – http://www.listoscalifornia.org/wp-content/uploads/508_LIS_026_050520_IDD_health_profile_dAf.pdf

National Fire Protection Association (NFPA) – <https://www.nfpa.org/Public-Education/Fire-causes-and-risks/Wildfire/Wildfire-safety-tips>

Pacific ADA Center – <https://www.adapacific.org/>

Public Safety Power Shutoff – <https://prepareforpowerdown.com/>

The Tsunami Zone – <https://www.tsunamizone.org/>